I, Freddy

By Dietlof Reiche

FREDDY: **(Pg 202)** *(Freddy – a hamster - uses his paws to type out a message on a keyboard, he voices the words as he types)* My life story . . . *(Freddy notices he has an audience and tries to hide or delete his message)*

MR. JOHN: **(Pg 198-199)** *(Freddy remembers Mr. John's words)* The fact that you can read and write must remain a secret between us. It wouldn't be long before some smart showman came along, eager to make a fortune out of Fantastic Freddy, the hamster that can read and write. Either that, or you'd wind up in the hands of scientists itching to dissect your brain for research purposes.

INTRODUCTION

(As Freddy) Well, I certainly don't want to be dissected for research purposes. . . But you all don't look like showmen or scientists, so I guess it's safe to tell you my story. Hi, my name is Freddy (waves) . . .

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FREDDY: **(Pg 3)** I was born the sixth of ten . . . **(Pg 2)** My birthplace was a cage . . . **(Pg 129)** and I can [read] and write! . . . **(Pg 2)** Maybe I should also mention I'm a hamster. *(Cleans his hamster face and scratches behind his ears)* **(Pg 1)** The time has come to make a start on my life story . . . A pretty bright youngster grows up in a kind of prison, is sold, eventually manages to escape, and is smart enough to gain his freedom. If that isn't a story, what is?

(Pg 3) I was born blind and naked . . . I didn't become a genuine hamster until my eyes opened . . . *(Reacts violently to the vision of Great-Grandmother in his face)* **(Pg 17)** *(then, in awe)* Great-Grandmother!

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G-GRANDMOTHER: **(Pg 21)** Now, youngsters, pay attention. [It's time for] **(Pg 17)** Saga Hour! **(Pg 21)** Rejoice! *(Freddy cheers)* **(Pg 18)** In the beginning was the Golden Trinity: three golden hamsters . . .

FREDDY: But, Great-Grandmother, what about the . . . .

G-GRANDMOTER: **(Pg 19-20)** Stop your nonsense! The saga is unalterable. You don't question it, you simply listen to it. Understand?

FREDDY: Yes, but . . .

G-GRANDMOTER: *(Harsher)* Hold your tongue! . . . **(Pg 18)** [These] three golden hamsters were abducted from the Promised Land of Assyria and carried off into captivity.

FREDDY: *(Freddy raises his paw with another question)*

G-GRANDMOTHER: **(Pg 20)** *(bares her teeth and flattens her ears; she hisses at Freddy and gives him the evil eye, Freddy slowly lowers his paw)* And now, I'll tell you [about] the Promised Land . . . Assyria! **(Pg 21)** One wonderful day, all the golden hamsters in the world [will] be released from captivity and led back to the Promised Land.

FREDDY: **(Pg 18)** But, Great Grandmother . . . **(Pg 21)** why?

G-GRANDMOTHER: *(So upset by the interruption, she can't even speak, she hisses, spits, has a fit and dies)*

FREDDY: **(Pg 3)** [Then] Great-Grandmother went into Eternal Hibernation. . . . **(Pg 7)** My thoughts went around and around in circles. I must get out of [this] cage . . . I must find **(Pg 24)** the Promised Land of Assyria. **(Pg 7)** The next golden hamster in our cage to be sold must be me! *(notices that people are peering into the cage)* **(Pg 10-13)** The fat salesclerk . . . and a man with a mustache!

SALESCLERK: How old is your little girl?

MAN WITH MUSTACHE: She's nearly six . . . Her name's Sophie.

FREDDY: Too young! Far too young!

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MAN WITH MUSTACHE: She spends a lot of time on her own, you see.

SALESCLERK: Great, so now she'll have a playmate.

MAN WITH MUSTACHE: She's only just learning to read. She's asked me to get a book about caring for golden hamsters.

FREDDY: That settled it! I launched into my routine. *(rushes to the middle of the cage, stands up on his hind legs, opens eyes wide . . . cleans face with paws and then raises right paw high and waves)*

MAN WITH MUSTACHE: *(Looking over all the options in the cage, he notices Freddy waving and waves back)* Okay. He'll do.

FREDDY: What followed was the worst time of my life, yet it began quite pleasantly. I was shut up in a fairly small box – hamsters are fond of confined spaces. But soon the box started to move. *(Freddy vibrates with the telling, loses his balance and regains it)* I was shaken around until I felt thoroughly nauseous. *(Freddy throws up a bit in his mouth)* An eternity later, the shaking ceased. *(A huge sigh of relief)*

MAN WITH MUSTACHE: Sophie! I've got something for you!

SOPHIE: What is it, Daddy? *(Sophie takes the box and peers inside)* **(Pg 14)** Oh, Daddy! *(she takes Freddy out of his box)* A golden hamster! Oh, Daddy, he's so cute. *(Turns to her mother)* Look, Mom! My hamster.

MOM: **(Pg 15)** *(Recoils in disgust)* You both know I wasn't crazy about this idea. A creature like this could bring diseases into the house. He doesn't look too chipper . . . more like he's sick! *(Mom coughs violently, blows her nose and coughs again, moaning and groaning)* **(Pg 29)** I'm getting a migraine! I'm going to lie down for a few hours . . . *(to Sophie)* **(Pg 28)** Finish your homework before you play with [that] hamster *(the last word is said in disgust)* !

SOPHIE: **(Pg 27)** *(Sophie heads solemnly off to her room with Freddy in her hands. When her mom is no longer in sight she breaks into a happy skip. She sits Freddy gently on her*

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desk and bends down to talk directly to him) You need a name. I [think I'll] call you Freddy.

FREDDY: Do I? In that case, why not Freddy? It sounded fresh and frisky, like me! *(Freddy wiggles his body, excited to be out of a cage and curious about his surroundings)* **(Pg 38-39)** So there I [was] on Sophie's desk, surrounded by pencils and schoolbooks and watched her start on . . . "homework." She was learning to read and write . . . a few strange marks on paper, and they meant something. Fantastic! T – R – E- E referred to a picture of a tree, so TREE meant tree. Huh! Far from difficult . . . **(Pg 42)** It occurred to me how useful reading could be to a golden hamster in that far off place . . . **(Pg 18)** [the Promised Land of Assyria.] **(Pg 42)** So I decided to learn to read! **(Pg 51)** The fact was, I learned to read so quickly, much quicker than Sophie. I was astonished!

****** scene break ******

FREDDY: **(Pg 77-79)** Morning came *(Freddy yawns, stretches as he awakens, then recoils in disgust as he notices)* Mom!! Her face all swollen up and the color of a tomato.

MOM: Sophie, wake up. *(Coughing fit, blows nose again, more coughing)*

SOPHIE: Mom! What's the matter with you?

MOM: An allergic reaction *(more coughing, sniffling, then insincerely)* I'm sorry, but I'm afraid the hairs from his fur are making me ill. *(hand to her forehead, dramatically)*

SOPHIE: But, but . . . but MOM! No, Mom! Please don't!

FREDDY: *(Sits up on his haunches to watch the show, grooms himself a little)*

MOM: Sophie . . You can't want your mother going around in this condition. And I'm running a fever! **(Pg 82)** I'm going to call John! *(Coughs dramatically and exits)*

SOPHIE: **(Pg 80)** *(runs to Freddy's cage and kneels down crying)*

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FREDDY: I hadn't realized she was quite so attached to me. **(Pg 89)** Sophie was a girl in a million! **(Pg 83)** *(Freddy's body is swaying during the transport and he speaks sadly)* I was transported in my cage, not the box I'd arrived in. **(Pg 85-86)** I crept deep into my burrow, feeling utterly miserable. So this was the end. Good-bye to reading . . . Good-bye, Sophie! *(The transportation movement stops . . . Freddy peeks out of his burrow and is surprised)* Hey! What's going on? Where on earth? I was at Mr. John's place [not] the pet shop! **(Pg 91)** *(Freddy quickly forgets Sophie and becomes more and more elated as he speaks)* Looking around, I saw that my cage was on a shelf . . . to the left and right of it? BOOKS! *(Freddy easily opens the door to his cage and begins to explore)* I had wound up in the land of milk and honey! What a stroke of luck! Books **(Pg 115)** that would take me on a fantastic journey to the Promised Land of Assyria! . . . . **(Pg 91)** And then I heard it . . . **(Pg 90)** a purring sound! *(Freddy peers over his shoulder and spies a cat on the shelf. He squeaks and hides his face)*

WILLIAM: *(a large furry house cat who is the size of a house compared to poor Freddy. He sits down, purrs, meows and ultimately speaks)* **(Pg 99)** You're Freddy, I presume. *(He gestures to himself expansively)* [I am] Sir William.

FREDDY: **(Pg 97)** *(finding courage . . . he rises on his hind legs, and puffs out his cheeks in an aggressive fighting stance)* Listen to me, tomcat!

WILLIAM: **(Pg 99)** *(unsheathing his claws one by one, but speaking calmly)* I find it quite absurd for a five-inch hamster to try to play the lion tamer with a cat of my size. (William chuckles) So kindly drop the act. Then, maybe we can have a civilized conversation.

FREDDY: **(Pg 177-178)** *(Feeling safe in the fact that William was not a threat, Freddy settles down)* [So] I recounted the whole story from the very beginning. I told him about Great-Grandmother and the Golden Hamster Saga; about my time with

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Sophie; about the way I'd learned to read . . . [and] about the far-off Promised Land of Assyria. *(reverently)* In short . . . A golden hamster in Assyria –

WILLIAM: *(breaking in)* . . . is a civilized domestic animal free to roam wherever it wants.

FREDDY: *(nodding)* Anyway, it's impossible to live like that without human cooperation. *(to audience)* **(Pg 111-112)** That's why I had to get in touch with Mr. John. Except I didn't have the faintest idea how to do so.

******* scene break *******

FREDDY: **(pg 137)** I'd been living at Mr. John's for five days [when] **(Pg 112)** Mr. John came into the study and sat down at the desk. **(Pg 151-153)** He pressed a button. A gong sounded, and some mysterious symbols and pictures appears on a screen. Mr. John was using this machine to write with!! Black letters appeared on the screen! As I watched him depressing keys with very little effort, I realized that this was the machine for me. With this machine, I could write!! **(Pg 202)** I made a start the very next day. To begin with, *(Freddy practices pushing down keys as he speaks, it is difficult at first, but gets easier and easier)* I limited myself to finger exercises – paw exercises, I mean. Before long, however, I could manipulate the keys so skillfully that I was able to type without difficulty . . . **(Pg 200)** "Thanks for everything . . . Freddy" **(Pg 196)** After that, I simply wait[ed], sitting on the desk, for Mr. John to come home. **(Pg 197)** Mr. John's response when he found my message on the screen?

MR. JOHN: Humm . . . **(Pg 162)** That would explain a couple of things . . . like certain changes to my bookshelves. *(Mr. John types and speaks aloud)* **(Pg 193)** Hi, There! Welcome Home, Freddy.

FREDDY: *(lifts a tiny paw to shake Mr. John's hand, which Mr. John does)*

MR. JOHN: **(Pg 199)** *(speaks to Freddy)* The fact that you can read and write must remain a secret between us. It wouldn't be long before some smart showman came along, eager to make a fortune out of Fantastic Freddy. Either that, or

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you'd wind up in the hands of scientists itching to dissect your brain for research purposes. Does either of those prospect appeal to you?

FREDDY: *(shakes his head emphatically)*

MR. JOHN: So it's a deal: strict secrecy.

FREDDY: *(Freddy nods emphatically)*

MR. JOHN: *(He picks up the phone)* Hello, Sophie . . .

FREDDY: **(Pg 200-201)** [Well] It wasn't long before Sophie turned up. **(Pg 61)** Sophie was a girl in a million. *(Freddy sits up an waves).*

SOPHIE: **(Pg 201)** *(Sophie picks him up)* Freddy, [you're] the bestest, smartest golden hamster in the world.

FREDDY: *(to himself)* You don't know how right you are, Sophie. *(winks at audience)*

SOPHIE: So . . . you're staying with Mr. John because you're better off here. But I'll come and visit you okay? *(Sophie kisses Freddy on the top of his head)*

FREDDY: *(Looks at the audience in embarrassment)* Sophie . . . [she's my] Promised Land of Assyria . . . . **(Pg 202)** *(Freddy turns to the keyboard)* Now I knew exactly what my story would be about . . . *(He speaks as he types)* . . . My Life Story . . . **(Pg 2)** Maybe I should mention . . . I'm a hamster.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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